

Code Name: Ghibli Game

0.0 What is Ghibli game

Ghibli game is a senior capstone project which will be produced by 4 seniors in Boise State's GIMM program. Jojo Noyes, Boon Burns, Lily Pinson, and Trey Bledsoe. The original concept which Jojo Noyes had created was a project built around many pillars of skill and knowledge.

The 4 pillars are

Direction and Story: Jojo

Programming: Boon Burns

Music and Reactive Audio: Trey Bledsoe

Art and design: Lily pinson

This project is meant to have 4 whole stories coming together to work as one coherent project. Ghibli will be built on a basis of no generative AI art, audio, visuals, story, or anything the player interacts with, and only AI assisted code which is mostly hand written. We will be using no generative AI in this project. We will be using some Algorithmic AI to help with code, but try to keep it mostly by hand. The 4 creators believe that an almost "second coming" of the renaissance will emerge because of AI. because everyone has the ability to create something, without much effort. There will be great works of art which will shine through the overbearing load of information and content in the age of AI.

The Ghibli game is inspired by many worlds which AI had no hand in, and we want to continue the trend of hand crafted and quality content and artwork.

1.0 Direction

This project will be directed by Jojo Noyes as he holds the original vision for the project. There will be lots of freedom for everyone else working on this project but for it to see the light of day, there will need to be direction and understanding of this group effort. Jojo will oversee and put together many parts of the game in unity. Jojo will also work with all the others to understand everything that is going into this game.

1.2 The inspiration

Jojo took lots of inspiration from studio ghibli projects and games, as well as some art intentions and vibes of Hoyoverse games. The heaviest inspiration for this project is Studio Ghibli's Spirited Away. This is probably Studio Ghibli's most well known and highest acclaimed movie. Which follows a girl named Chihiro and her journey through an odd hotel, with magic, old grudges, and beautiful sights. It can be enjoyed by kids and adults alike finding a unique space of visuals, story, and audio like music for viewers of all types to enjoy. Our team aims to create a similar experience. One that can be played by all ages, with amazing visuals, audio, story, and interaction. Our aim is to please people who are technically versed and inclined, and those who aren't. To create a story with depth for those who are media literate, but also a story everyone can enjoy. To create a beautiful crafted piece with human hands.

1.4 The Vision

The original Vision Jojo had for this project was very vague when it comes to many parts except one thing. The Vibe of Studio Ghibli films, and specifically spirited away. The Idea has had some time to mature with input from all the other members and has become a unique idea shared by multiple people. A beautiful art piece that can be interacted with and admired featuring unique audio visualizations, smooth and easy code and controls, a unique and heavily stylized artstyle, and a story which can be enjoyed on the surface, but also has deeper meaning if inspected.

1.6 The Game Idea

Ghibli games main idea will take place in a world with 3 main areas. The city which is a small piece of a modern town. This will have tall buildings and tight corners with lots of people and city culture of the world to enjoy. Only a small corner will be available but will play a role in the story. Then there will be the ponds. These are an area on the map where PotBelly frog fishermen live, a unique creature to our world which is a frog that walks with 2 legs, and is inspired by asian fishermen. There will be a story here, and it will be a beautiful place to explore. And the main piece of the story and visuals will take place in the hotel. This will be a grand hotel where many different types of people and creatures will come to stay. Offering many of the luxuries of a Japanese Onsen Ryokan, while also maintaining high quality status and fame for a hotel in this world. The main character will get to know the staff, large and small, important and maybe neglected. They will be able to see and explore this world through others' stories and their own eyes. Many of the tasks will be based around jobs at the hotel and much of the story will progress by helping up keep the hotel.

1.8 The Story

You will play as a character who ends up in a mysterious world not like your own. You don't remember fully how you got here. Just that it's a new world and you know nothing about it. In the beginning you will find yourself dropped off by a train in front of the hotel. As you step out. The doors close, and you move to the hotel. When you enter it's full of people and life. You feel a little out of place not knowing anything about this place. So you go to the check in window and you begin asking questions. The owner greets you and offers you a place to stay for now while you figure some things out in place of chores you can do around the hotel. And the story begins there. You will explore and begin to understand things through the lens of the hotel. There will be puzzles and timed objectives. As the story progresses your memories will fade in and out. People you remember and miss. A life you seem to have lived mixed with melancholy and a general sense of sadness. You will find the hotel is involved with magic, culture, and other things which make it a one of a kind place. But there is some business which needs to be taken care of which the owner knows but tries to hide and you get involved with a pretty clear bad guy. That's part of the magic of ghibli and the simplicity is there is always a clear good and bad force. And we will follow this solution. But we will make it more complex in the emotions and character of the villain as we haven't decided on them yet.

2.0 The Visual

This section discusses the visual and artistic direction of the Ghibli-game. The overall visual style of this game will help determine how the story carries across to the player. We intend for it to carry emotional weight for the players, striking a chord of nostalgia. We want to drive home the notion of how impactful and important handmade art is.

2.1 Artstyle

Our team wants to capture the style of classic Studio Ghibli movies in the form of an immersive digital experience. As such, this game will have a very painterly aspect with saturated colors, and artistic lighting.



Uploaded by BlueCrystalStudio on Reddit titled: My take on Ghibli style in Unity

2.2 VFX and Shaders

The majority of this experience will utilize toon shaders and low poly assets to help push a very stylized and simplistic but still artistic look while maintaining a painterly effect. Our team wants to really lean into the heavy stylization that Unity URP will allow.

3.0 Music : A Storyteller

When Jojo first ideated this project, he stated that this project is not just a game, but a thesis on art incarnate. For this end, music and visuals must not just be present in this project, they must all share the same breath. The musical goal for this project is to enrich the storytelling through connecting melodies, motifs, and rhythmic intent. For the audio goal, inspired by games such as 'Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild', the audio should not only match/mimic the emotions and visuals present in the scene, the audio should foreshadow, allude, and prepare the player for actions that will happen in the scene. (Here is a waltz feel that Trey created to show the vibe of the game: [Homeward.wav](#))

3.1 Motifs : The Language of the Game

For both general reactive audio, as well as musical compositions, the story will be told through the interactions between small musical themes called Motifs. Motifs can (and will) represent things as specific as characters, and as broad as the concept of 'closure'.

3.2 Wwise Integration

This project is meant to be as 'industry standard' as possible, so we will be exploring what it takes to integrate Wwise into Unity and cohesively use it across multiple devices through GitHub.

3.3 Interactive / Reactive Audio Systems

Working with Boon, we will be creating an adaptive system that will work as our audio mixer and triggerer based on functions and triggers in-game (similar to the button ui and functions built into Unity).

3.4 Teaching

What will be taught to the class: How to use different scale types, modes, motifs, instrumentation, and rhythm (as well as overall timing) to tell a story and convey a theme in media

4.0 Development & Technical Systems

This section outlines the core technical architecture and gameplay systems required to build Ghibli-game. The primary goal is to create a seamless, immersive "Ghibli-esque" experience where the player transitions between exploration, conversation, and questing smoothly and cozily.

4.1 Scene Management & World Streaming

To capture the feeling of a living, breathing hotel, the game will utilize a Hybrid Scene Management System.

Persistent World: The Hotel is divided into logical "Zones" (e.g., The Boiler Room, The Bathhouse Main Floor, The Guest Suites).

Seamless Transitions: We will use asynchronous loading (loading screens disguised as narrative transitions or door-opening animations) to prevent immersion breaks.

Time of Day (ToD) Manager: The scene manager will track the global time state (Day/Night cycles). Lighting, NPC schedules, and available quests will update dynamically based on this manager.

4.2 Camera System

The camera is a critical tool for storytelling and must mimic the cinematic framing of Studio Ghibli films.

Exploration Camera: A third-person, fixed-angle camera system. Instead of full 360-degree control, the camera will snap to "beautiful angles" (hand-placed by designers) within rooms to frame the environment like a painting. Players can rotate slightly within these limits.

Dialogue Camera: Dynamic camera cuts during conversations (Over-the-shoulder, extreme close-ups on faces, wide shots showing both characters) to emphasize emotional beats.

Cinematic Mode: A spline-based camera path system for cutscenes, events or tasks too close to the walls, and major story events.

4.3 Interaction System

The player must interact with the world in a tactile way (cooking, cleaning, grabbing items).

Context-Sensitive Interaction: A single "Interact" button that changes function based on the sphere collision targets (e.g., "Talk," "Pick Up," "Cook," "Clean").

Event-Exposed Visual Feedback: Use "Ghibli-style" particle effects (sparkles, dust motes) to indicate interactable objects from the event-exposed interaction system.

Physics-Based Interactions: Simple physics for picking up objects to make the world feel tangible.

4.4 Dialogue System

The narrative is the core of the game. The system must support complex branching and localization.

Data-Driven Structure: Dialogue will be written in ScriptableObjects for easy editing and event-specific implementation. These might be convertible to JSONs for easy creation and save-loading. They will be easy to make new subclasses from to add to the system.

Branching Logic: Support for:

Hub-and-Spoke: Returning to a central topic list.

Conditionals: Dialogue is accessible based on Player Level, Inventory, or previous Quest completion.

Timed Responses: For tense negotiations with npcs.

4.5 NPC System

NPCs need to feel like they are alive and have lives of their own.

Schedule System: NPCs have specific locations and behaviors based on the Time of Day (e.g., Working in the bath, sleeping in the dorms).

Navigation Mesh (NavMesh): Robust pathfinding to navigate the complex, multi-level geometry of the hotel.

Fuzzy Logic States: NPCs will have states (Idle, Working, Talking, Angry, Fleeing) that shift based on player actions or story triggers.

Crowd Simulation: Background NPCs will use "flocking" behaviors to move in groups, creating a bustling atmosphere.

Player-Mocking: Not quite an inventory system or interaction system, but NPCs will be able to do some of the things the player can.

4.6 Quest System

A robust system to manage the "Right Quests" and Main Storyline.

Data-Driven Quest system: A ScriptableObject based system for designers to link Main Quests and Side Quests.

Objective Types:

Fetch: Retrieve an item.

Task: Perform a mini-game (e.g., scrubbing a tub).

Stealth.

Avoid detection by certain spirits.

Return and item that a thief stole.

Report back to an NPC.

Hidden Quests: The system will track "World Flags" (actions the player did not know were being tracked) to unlock secret quests later.

4.7 Inventory System

The inventory should reflect the "cluttered but cozy" aesthetic of the film.

Immersive Grid-Based UI: A visual representation of the player's bag.

Item Categories: Consumables, Quest Items, Gifts, and Magical Artifacts.

Crafting system(?): Players can drag items onto each other to combine them (e.g., Herb + Water = Medicine).

4.8 UI (User Interface)

The UI must be diegetic where possible, minimizing "gamey" overlays.

Main HUD: Minimalist. Current objectives fade out when not in combat or interaction.

Diegetic Elements: Menus designed to look like the hotel's ledger book or scrolls.

Accessibility: Full subtitle support, colorblind modes, and text-scaling options.

4.9 Save/Load System

Given the complex state of the world (NPC schedules, quest progress, inventory), the save system must be robust.

Serialization: Saving the state of:

Player Transform and Inventory.

Active Quest States.

World Flags.

Maybe NPC Locations.

Autosave: Triggered upon entering new zones or completing major quest steps.

Manual Save(?): Allowed only at specific "rest points" (e.g., the player's bed).

4.10 Achievements System

Including the world flag system.

Narrative Achievements: Unlocked by completing specific story arcs.

Exploration Achievements: "Found the hidden garden," "Listened to all of Kamaji's stories."

Mastery Achievements: Completing all side quests or mastering a mini-game.

World Flags: Some things are or aren't accessible when the player does something.